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BRICS, the G20 and the American Empire

Leo Panitch

For most of the 20th century, the widespread influence of Marxism around the world had a lot to do with its explanation of the new relationship between capitalism and imperialism that gave rise to the Great War. We cannot know what Marx would have made of the way Lenin identified imperialism with 'the highest stage of capitalism', but there was unquestionably a certain symmetry between *Das Kapital*'s famous description of capital as having come 'into the world dripping from head to foot, from every pore, with blood and dirt' and Lenin's expectation that it was in the process of leaving the world in the same way. Indeed, in 1888, five years after Marx's death, Engels had explicitly raised the prospect of 'a world war of an extent and violence hitherto unimagined … irretrievable dislocation of our artificial system of trade, industry and credit, ending in universal bankruptcy, collapse of the old states and their conventional political wisdom … and the creation of the conditions for the ultimate victory of the working class.'[1]

Of course, we can see today just how much more time capitalism had to run, and how much more space it had yet to conquer, despite the wars, revolutions and depressions it spawned in the first half of the 20th century. But the link the Marxist theorists of imperialism made between the export of capital and the inter-imperial rivalry of those years was, in fact, problematic even in its own time.[2] It failed to give sufficient weight to the continuing role of pre-capitalist ruling classes in driving territorial expansion and militarism. It far too narrowly saw state behaviour as subject to the exclusive and direct control of capitalists. And it far too directly associated the export of capital with the old history of